legends, endowing an Ajivika figure with the power of prophecy probably gave credibility to the legends.

The other noticeable element about these tales is that they are all retrospective predictions made several centuries after Ashoka occupied the Mauryan throne. The version of his early life in which the Buddha prophesied his future, and in which the soothsayers in Champa and the Ajivika Pingalavatsa in Pataliputra figure, is earlier and forms part—as we saw—of the *Ashokavadana*. There are several layers of tradition in the text, some of which possibly go back to the late centuries BCE.[41] In its present form, though, the *Ashokavadana* was, as noted, composed in or after the second century CE, which makes its prediction some four centuries after the time of Ashoka. A variety of related prophecies pop up at its very beginning, when the Buddha predicts the future birth of a Buddha-like figure. One hundred years after his death, he says at this point, a son will be born to a perfumer in Mathura who will carry forward his own work.[42] Prediction, then, whether of the birth of a future Buddha or a Buddhist king, is a specific narrative device that was culturally common when speaking of the 'coming' of figures important to the Buddhist tradition.

The second version worth noting is from the *Vamshatthapakasini*, a commentary on the *Mahavamsa*, the Sri Lankan Buddhist chronicle which was written 800 years or so after the *Ashokavadana* and more than 1200 after the death of Ashoka—i.e. in the ninth or tenth century CE. In the main text, the *Mahavamsa*, dated to the fifth century CE, one encounters soothsayers making predictions about royal children on various occasions. The ancestor of the first king of Indian descent, named Vijaya, is shown as the son of a king who was said to have been born of the union of a woman and a lion. This woman was a princess whom the soothsayers had prophesied as soon to be united with the 'king of beasts'.[43] Elsewhere in the text we are told that when Brahmans skilled in sacred texts saw the only daughter of a later king, Panduvasudeva, they foretold her son as slaying his